

over four months and 59 RTI applications to various ministries apart from PMO and the Cabinet Secretariat, before the information could be compiled and made available. The air distances have been calculated in approximation. Where the city was not mentioned, the distance from Delhi to the capital city of the destination country was considered. Expenses incurred were calculated on the basis of the per diem allowance that ministers are entitled to, since the RTI provided us information only about the number of trips and the number of days that each minister spent abroad. Here are some highlights of foreign travel by the UPA ministers.

It may come as no great surprise but Commerce and Industry Minister Kamal Nath, last spotted in Davos, logged the maximum mileage on foreign trips and created some sort of a record in the bargain. He spent 424 days on 72 trips outside the country, of which 27 days were spent on six personal visits. A cool 14 months spent outside India. He covered 10,08,162 km up to November 30, 2007 (enough to earn frequent flier miles to make 20 free trips to the US and back, assuming he flew first class) and the Government spent Rs 1.81

crore on his official visits. As commerce minister and head negotiator for India in the World Trade Organisation deliberations, he is obliged to travel abroad fairly frequently. And with trade and economic relations assuming far greater importance, he is more visible than the external affairs minister when the prime minister goes abroad as was the case recently in Beijing. The cities he has visited most frequently, whether privately or on official work, are London, Kuala Lumpur, Bangkok, New York, Paris and Brussels. In comparison, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram spent a mere 118 days on overseas visits, for which the Government picked up a tab of Rs 1.45 crore.

Minister of State (Mos) for Civil Aviation (independent charge) Praful Patel made 41 trips abroad of which 16 were official. He chose to visit the US six times and the UK five times, besides France and Belgium. Records show that the cities Patel visited most frequently in his personal capacity are London, Paris, New York, Singapore, Kuala Lumpur, Bangkok and Dubai. However, being a businessman of some standing would explain why he spent more time abroad on personal visits in comparison to

Kantilal Bhuria

Mos for agriculture & consumer affairs

Number of trips: 8

Km travelled: 1,18,769

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 80.8 lakh

Santosh Mohan Dev

Minister for heavy ind & public enterprises

Number of trips: 8

Km travelled: 1,03,645

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 52 lakh

Shankersinh Vaghela

Minister for textiles

Number of trips: 8

Km travelled: 1,37,494

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Not provided

Prem Chand Gupta

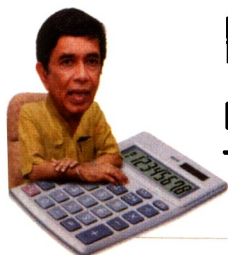
Minister for corporate affairs

Number of trips: 7

Km travelled: 57,388

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Not provided



Fernandes's previous ministry (statistics) has taken him to more foreign shores—Australia, Geneva, Italy, South Korea, Thailand (thrice) etc—than his present one.

Oscar Fernandes, MoS (I.C.) for labour and employment

Kamal Nath

Minister for commerce and industry

Days as minister: 1,287

NUMBER OF TRIPS: 72

Official: 66

Personal: 6

DAYS ABROAD: 424

Official: 397

Personal: 27

Km travelled: 10,08,162

Official: 9,33,650 km

Personal: 74,512 km

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 1.81 crore



Nath has covered over 10-lakh km, which could earn him enough frequent flier miles to make 20 free trips to the US and back assuming he flew first class.